

The men who made the summer

Trophies tell only part of a World Cup story. Across six weeks and 104 matches, five players rose above the noise, leaving behind **performances** that will define the tournament long after the final whistle.

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At 39, Messi didn't merely survive another World Cup. For much of it, he dictated its story. He finished with eight goals and four assists, collected the Silver Ball, and carried Argentina to within one extra-time goal of retaining its title.

His opening hat-trick against Algeria made him the oldest player to score three in a World Cup match. A brace against Austria then moved him beyond Miroslav Klose as the competition's leading scorer, before he came off the bench to find the net against Jordan. In the knockout stage, he scored against Cape Verde and inspired Argentina's comeback from two goals down against Egypt, first creating Cristian Romero's header and then striking the equaliser.

Messi's defining contribution came without scoring. With Argentina trailing England in the semifinal, he supplied both late assists in a 2-1 comeback, including the stoppage-time delivery for Lautaro Martinez. Spain finally found the answer in the final, keeping him largely quiet and restricting Argentina to no shot in normal time. His first attempt arrived only in the 117th minute.

The finish wasn't the one Argentina wanted. Even so, Messi's sixth and final World Cup served as another reminder that the game's greatest players don't always need a trophy to define a tournament.

APPEARANCES

8

GOALS

8



Lionel Messi